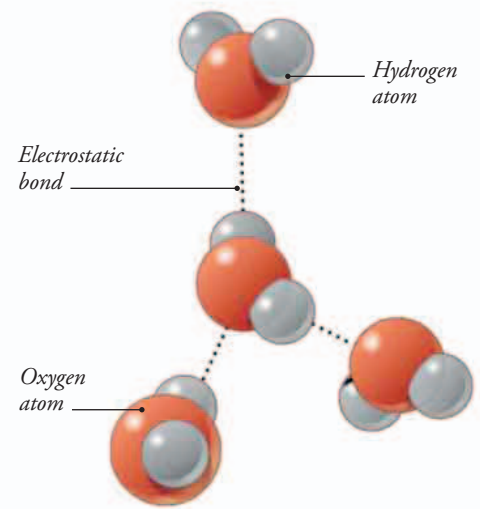


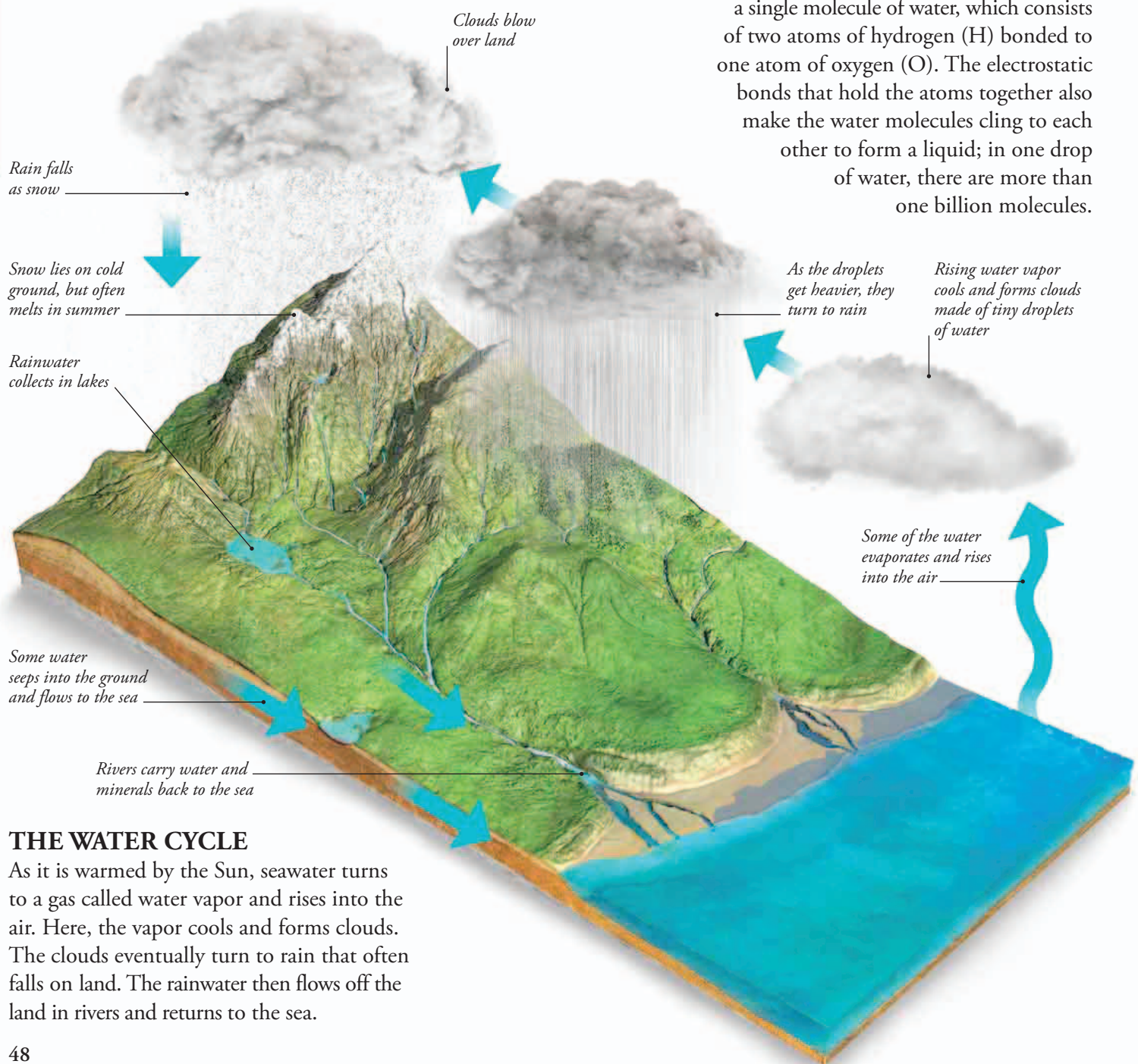
Ocean water

What is water? We are so used to it that we don't give it much thought, but water is a remarkable substance with some unique properties. It is also vital to life, and seawater especially contains most of the chemicals that living things need to grow and multiply.



WATER MOLECULE

Water is often called H_2O . This describes a single molecule of water, which consists of two atoms of hydrogen (H) bonded to one atom of oxygen (O). The electrostatic bonds that hold the atoms together also make the water molecules cling to each other to form a liquid; in one drop of water, there are more than one billion molecules.



THE WATER CYCLE

As it is warmed by the Sun, seawater turns to a gas called water vapor and rises into the air. Here, the vapor cools and forms clouds. The clouds eventually turn to rain that often falls on land. The rainwater then flows off the land in rivers and returns to the sea.